

Parisian Neoclassicism

Neoclassicism had surfaced in architectural design late in Louis XVI's reign, emerging more fully during the first Napoleonic Empire as architects experimented with a range of civic buildings. It had begun with the Church of Saint Genevieve – or the Panthéon – in Paris (1756–97), designed by Jacques-Germain Soufflot (1713–80), which combines the purity and magnificence of Greek architecture with the lightness and daring of Gothic construction. This unorthodox interpretation of classical forms became even bolder leading up to the French Revolution, with the Royal Saltworks at Arc-et-Senans (1775–8), designed by Claude-Nicolas Ledoux (1736–1806), and the Arc de Triomphe (1806–36), by Jean Chalgrin (1739–1811). The Place de la Concorde, an octagon spanning 359 x 212 metres (1,176 x 696 ft), bordered by the River Seine to the south and neoclassical buildings to the north, was designed by Ange-Jacques Gabriel (1698–1782) in 1755; Pierre-Alexandre Vignon (1763–1828) designed the Church of the Madeleine (c.1842, opposite), a monumental temple-like building with Corinthian columns.

